Pairing & Mobbing

Choose a style, rotate partners, agree how sessions run, and use pairing to spread skills across the team.

Manage Flow · Pair Programming · Mob / Ensemble Programming · Pair Stair · Spread Skills

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

TEAM: Basket team

DATE: 12 May

1 Styles

PICK ONE PER SESSION · WORKS FOR CODE, TESTS, ANALYSIS AND DESIGN

Driver / Navigator

One types (driver), one thinks ahead and reviews (navigator). Swap roles every 15–30 minutes.

Use it for: risky payments code

Swap every: 20 minutes

Ping-Pong

A writes a failing test, B makes it pass and writes the next test. Great with test-driven development.

Use it for: new features, test first

Swap every: each test

Strong-Style

"For an idea to go from your head into the computer, it must go through someone else's hands."

Use it for: teaching Ravi the codebase

Swap every: 15 minutes

Mob / Ensemble

The whole group, one keyboard. The driver rotates every few minutes. Ideal for swarming.

Use it for: swarms and tricky bugs

Swap every: 10 minutes

2 Pair Stair

TALLY EACH PAIRING · SPREAD IT OUT

		P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6	P7	P8
P1	Priya								
P2	Sam	/							
P3	Jo		////						
P4	Alex	//	//	/					
P5	Mei	///		///					
P6	Tom				/				
P7	Ravi		///	//	//				
P8									

Write names on the left. Add a tally where two people pair. Empty cells = pairs to try.

3 Session Agreements

We pair or mob by default on: payments; new joiners' work

We work solo on: small fixes, spikes

Swap roles every (min): 20

Take a break every (min): 50

Rotate partners every: iteration

Setup & tools: big screen, shared editor

- [x] Anyone can call a break or a swap
- [x] Navigators ask questions, not orders

4 Skills to Spread

FROM THE SKILLS MATRIX

SKILL	LEARNER	TEACHER	PAIR / MOB
Payments	Jo	Sam	pair
Test automation	Ravi	Alex	ping-pong
Data	Tom	Priya	pair
Cloud, CI/CD	Alex	Platform	mob

5 This Week's Pairs

WORK ITEM	WHO	STYLE
Substitute suggestions	Sam + Jo	driver / navigator
Reorder test suite	Ravi + Alex	ping-pong

6 Quick Retro

AFTER A SESSION OR AT THE END OF THE WEEK

What worked?

Jo now reviews payments code

fewer review waits

What was hard?

pairing all day is tiring

the mob felt slow at first

Next time we'll…

a break every 50 minutes

rotate pairs on Mondays

"Who haven't we paired with yet, and what could we learn from each other?"

"What would finish faster if two of us worked on it?"

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